

Guidelines for Prevention and Regulation of Greenwashing or Misleading Environmental Claims, 2024 - Compiled Summary

COMPILED SUMMARY - NOT THE OFFICIAL VERBATIM TEXT. This document is a summary compiled from the Central Consumer Protection Authority's official notification announcement, Press Information Bureau releases, and corroborating legal commentary. It is not, and does not replace, the Gazette notification. For binding wording, consult the official Gazette of India notification dated 15 October 2024. Compiled September 2026.

1. Issuing authority and status. Issued by the Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) under the Consumer Protection Act, 2019. A draft was published for public comment on 20 February 2024; the final Guidelines were notified on 15 October 2024.

2. Who these Guidelines apply to. Manufacturers, service providers, traders, advertisers, advertising agencies, and endorsers who make an environmental claim in connection with the advertisement or sale of goods or services.

3. Definition of "greenwashing". Greenwashing is any deceptive or misleading practice, including: concealing, omitting, or hiding relevant information; exaggerating, vague, false, or unsubstantiated environmental claims; and the use of misleading words, symbols, or imagery that places emphasis on positive environmental aspects while downplaying or concealing harmful ones.

4. Substantiation duty. An environmental claim must be truthful, accurate, and backed by verifiable evidence. The advertiser must be able to disclose the methodology and data underlying the claim on request.

5. Generic and vague terms. Terms such as "green", "eco-friendly", "eco-conscious", "good for the planet", "minimal impact", "cruelty-free", "carbon-neutral", "natural", "organic", "pure", "sustainable", "regenerative", or similar, must not be used without adequate, accurate, and accessible qualifiers explaining the specific basis for the claim.

6. Claims requiring independent verification. Claims such as "compostable", "degradable", "recyclable", or "climate-positive" require statutory or credible independent third-party certification before they can be used.

7. Disclosure requirements. Any certification, seal, or endorsement relied on for an environmental claim must be disclosed along with the certifying body and, where relevant, any material connection (e.g. payment) between the advertiser and the certifier.

8. Enforcement. The Guidelines do not set out a separate penalty scale of their own. Enforcement runs through the Central Consumer Protection Authority's general powers under the Consumer Protection Act, 2019 for false or misleading advertisement and unfair trade practice (recall of goods/withdrawal of services, discontinuation of the advertisement, and the Act's penalty provisions for the advertiser, manufacturer, and endorser). Consult the Consumer Protection Act, 2019 (already in this corpus) for the applicable penalty provisions and procedure.

9. Relationship to other CCPA instruments. These Guidelines supplement, and are to be read alongside, the CCPA's Guidelines for Prevention of Misleading Advertisements and Endorsements for Misleading Advertisements, 2022 (already in this corpus).

Sources relied on for this summary: Press Information Bureau release PRID 2064963 (Central

Consumer Protection Authority Issues Guidelines for 'Prevention and Regulation of Greenwashing and Misleading Environmental Claims'); Press Information Bureau release PRID 2007403 (draft guidelines, public comment); Ministry of Consumer Affairs notification announcement, 15 October 2024. This summary does not include a penalty schedule because none was found in the secondary sources reviewed - do not treat that silence as meaning no penalty applies; refer to the Consumer Protection Act, 2019 and, once available, the official Gazette text.